The one group which seemed taken up by the AAP white topi were the Muslim weavers. Travelling through the weaver bastis, I was confronted by the sense of hopelessness that stared at the Indian Muslim in this election. The local artisans could spin magical saris, but their lives were caught in a cycle of neglect and relative poverty. A superior quality Banarasi sari could range from Rs 30,000 to Rs 50,000 but the artisan would be lucky to earn Rs 5000 for his month-long effort while working out of a cramped little room. It was a terribly unequal world.

That sense of inequality had seeped down to political choices as well. The Congress, the weavers felt, had let them down. A number of promises and packages had been announced, but little had trickled down to them. The SP and the BSP exploited them as a vote bank with no obvious reward. A Modi-led BJP frightened them. *'Woh toh danga karvatein hain'* (He stages riots). The AAP was a more enticing prospect. Wearing an AAP badge and cap, one weaver told me, *'Kejriwalji hamari bhasha bol rahe hain, BJP ko wahi ek takkar de sakte hain'* (Kejriwal is speaking our language, only he can give a fight to the BJP). Yet Kejriwal's dilemma was that if he became a Muslim-focused party, the AAP would alienate the Hindus. The message of the public transport-using, sleeping-on-the-footpath common man up against a business-class Modi with his powerful corporate backers was far more politically expedient.

I accompanied Kejriwal on his campaign into the villages around Varanasi. In searingly hot temperatures, he seemed to be up for the challenge. 'Modi is a *hawai* neta, he comes in and out on choppers. I am a *zameeni* neta, on the ground,' he told me. His election rhetoric had a familiar ring: *'Modi Adani–Ambani ke saath juda hua hain, woh paisa banayenge, aapko koi phayda nahi hoga'* (Modi is in partnership with Adani and Ambani. They will make money, you will get no benefit). But in rural Varanasi, this line of attack was misplaced and just did not resonate. No one I spoke to in the village had heard of Ambani or Adani.

I asked Kejriwal later whether he felt he had erred in contesting from Varanasi. After all, his presence meant that the entire AAP volunteer machine had been diverted to this single constituency. 'No, I don't agree.